

The objective of this research was to examine the relationships between the dependent variable of work-family conflict (operationalized as overload, work to family interference, family to work interference) and the independent variables of gender, family type, and perceived control. The sample consisted of 1,989 single-parent and dual-income employees with children ages 6 through 12. The findings indicated that individuals with higher perceived control have lower levels of overload and interference. Women had higher levels of overload and interference than did men. Single parents had similar levels of overload and interference from family to work as married individuals.

## **Work-Family Conflict**

### **A Comparison by Gender, Family Type, and Perceived Control\***

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Canadian census data indicate that the two-income family has become the dominant family form in Canada during the 1990s. In 1961, only 20% of all two-parent families in Canada reported that both spouses worked outside the home. By 1981, this had increased to almost 40% and, by 1991, 65% of husband and wife families had dual incomes. High levels of divorce in Canada have also contributed to an increase in the number of single-parent families in the labor force. In 1991, 12.8% of Canadian families were classified as single-parent families (i.e., divorced, never married, or widowed parents), the majority of which are headed by women (Statistics Canada, 1993).

Dual-income and single-parent families represent a marked shift from traditional family relationships. The impact these changes to the family

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have on individuals, organizations, and families is an important area of research. Whereas the literature suggests that problems balancing work and family demands will be experienced differently by families depending on how they allocate employment and family roles (Portner, 1983), our understanding of the effect of this phenomenon on work and family-role behaviors lags behind the growth of the phenomenon itself (Yogev & Brett, 1985).

One major outcome of the inability to balance work and family is work-family conflict. Work-family conflict occurs when an individual has to perform multiple roles: worker, spouse, and in many cases parent (Greenhaus & Beutell, 1985). Each of these roles imposes demands requiring time, energy, and commitment to perform the role adequately. The cumulative demands of multiple roles can result in role strain of three types: overload, interference from work to family, and interference from family to work.

Overload exists when the total demands on time and energy associated with the prescribed activities of multiple roles are too great to perform the roles adequately or comfortably. Interference from family to work occurs when family-role responsibilities hinder performance at work (i.e., a child's illness prevents attendance at work). Interference from work to family arises when work-role activities impede performance of family responsibilities (i.e., long hours in paid work prevent the performance of duties at home) (Gutek, Searle, & Kelpa, 1991).

There are many factors that affect perceptions of work-family conflict. In this article, we examine gender, family type, and perceived control. In particular, this research empirically investigates how gender, family type, and perceived control affect role overload, interference from work to family, and interference from family to work in working parents.

An empirical examination of impact of gender, family type, and perceived control such as that presented in this analysis is needed before policymakers and employers can fully understand the issues that are unique to and shared between different family types (Gupta & Jenkins, 1985). Little has been done to establish the viability of the proposition that dual-income issues are qualitatively different from those experienced by single-parent families (Gupta & Jenkins, 1985). Comprehensive studies of single-parent families have been limited. As Burden (1986) noted:

Since single parenthood is a transitory state . . . and since at any given point only 16% of the female workforce is divorced, separated or widowed, studies tend to either include single mothers under the general category of employed mothers or exclude them altogether. . . . Studies tend to disregard single fathers and employment altogether. (p. 38)

## CONCEPTUAL APPROACH

Given the multiple and complex links between work and family spheres, no one unifying theoretical framework exists within the field. Specialized literature relevant to the work and family domains have examined work and nonwork roles from a number of different perspectives (Bureau of National Affairs, 1988; Galinsky, 1989; Galinsky, Friedman, & Hernandez, 1991; Galinsky & Stein, 1990; Googins & Burden, 1986; Greenhaus & Parasuraman, 1986; Gutek, Repetti, & Silver, 1988; Gutek, Searle, & Kelpa, 1991; Hall & Richter, 1988; Kabanoff, 1980; Kanter, 1977; Near, Rice, & Hunt, 1980; Pleck, 1977; Staines, 1980; Voydanoff, 1987, 1990). Research findings from studies done during the 1960s and 1970s must, however, be interpreted cautiously because changing norms and attitudes toward women's employment may have altered the relationship between work and family for today's employees.

Hypotheses tested in this analysis are based on both the rational model of work-family conflict (Greenhaus, Bedeian, & Mossholder, 1987; Keith & Schafer, 1980; Staines, Pleck, Shepard, & O'Connor, 1978) and the job strain model developed by Karasek (1979).

The rational view of work-family conflict proposes that the amount of conflict one perceives rises in proportion to the number of hours one expends in both the work and family domains (Greenhaus et al., 1987; Keith & Schafer, 1980; Staines et al., 1978). According to this view, the more hours a person spends in work activities, the more he or she should experience interference from work to family. The more time spent in family activities (i.e., home chores and child care), the more he or she should experience interference from family to work. The rational view also predicts that the total amount of time spent performing work and family roles is positively associated with role overload (Greenhaus & Beutell, 1985; Gutek et al., 1991).

Karasek's (1979) two-dimensional model of work strain provides a structure for understanding the relationship between perceived control and stress. Karasek's model focuses on describing the objective conditions conducive to stress. He identifies two key operating forces: role demands and control. His job strain model asserts that jobs with similar demands or expectations may differ substantially in the degree of stress generated by virtue of the degree of individual control over the situation (LaCroix & Haynes, 1987). Karasek (1979) has envisioned that a job characterized by high demands produces stress only when accompanied by constraints placed on the worker in terms of the possible mechanisms for coping with

the demands. According to Karasek, the most stressful set of job conditions combines having little control and having highly demanding tasks. Presumably, the high demands create arousal, and the inability to exert control leads to frustration and stress.

Although Karasek's original model was limited to the prediction of stress in the workplace, the results may also be applicable to the prediction of work-family conflict as the two have been shown to be interrelated (Googins, 1991). That is, the amount of conflict between work and family that occurs from family-role responsibilities interfering with work should decrease as the amount of control one has over family demands increases. Similarly, the amount of conflict between work and family that occurs from work-role responsibilities interfering with family-role demands should decrease as the amount of control one has over work demands increases.

## **HYPOTHESES**

### **IMPACT OF GENDER**

The rational model of work-family conflict suggests that mothers will experience more role overload than will fathers because their combined work and family demands are higher (Rexroat & Shehan, 1987). The rational model also predicts that men should experience more work to family interference than should women because men tend to spend more time in work activities than do women (Pleck, 1985). Women, on the other hand, should experience more family to work interference than should men because women take primary responsibility for the family and thus spend more time in family activities than do men (Piotrkowski, Rapoport, & Rapoport, 1987; Pleck, 1985; Rexroat & Shehan, 1987). For most men, the dual-income situation differs fundamentally from that experienced by their spouses because, by tradition, the "second shift" (i.e., home chores) does not fall to men (Hochschild, 1989). Although recent studies indicate that the vast majority of husbands and wives believe that the husband should do more around the house when the wife is employed, most research indicates that a persistent discrepancy exists between espoused egalitarian ideals about division of household labor and actual involvement in household and parental roles (Gilbert, 1985; Piotrkowski et al., 1987; Rexroat & Shehan, 1987). The hypotheses are as follows:

- H1: Mothers will experience more role overload than will fathers.  
 H2: Fathers will experience more interference from work to family than will mothers.  
 H3: Mothers will experience more interference from family to work than will fathers.

### **IMPACT OF FAMILY TYPE**

Two main family types are considered in this analysis: dual-income and single-parent families. In the single-parent pattern, one parent is responsible for both work and family responsibilities. In the dual-income pattern, male and female partners are each responsible for employment and household responsibilities.

Single parents share some of the same sources of work-family conflict as do their dual-income counterparts. Both must deal with issues of role overload from the sheer total volume of activities involved in work and family life (Lee, 1983), and both must coordinate family activities with work demands. However, important differences have been noted between the two groups. Belle (1990), Norton and Glick (1986), Tebbets (1982), and Burden (1986) have suggested three reasons why single parents will be more susceptible to work-family conflict than will dual-income parents: (a) the centrality of the work role to the identity of single parents, (b) the economic imperative for them to work, and (c) the fact that single parents have fewer options to leave unsatisfactory employment.

Role demands are greater in single-parent households because one person must perform most of the family tasks that are performed by two partners in a dual-income family (Lee, 1983; Voydanoff, 1987). The rational model would thus predict higher levels of overload and interference from family to work for single parents. The rational model does not support any hypothesis regarding work to family interference because there is no reason to posit differing work demands between single and married parents. The following hypotheses are tested:

- H4: Single parents will experience more role overload than will dual-income parents.  
 H5: Single parents will experience more interference from family to work than will dual-income parents.

### **IMPACT OF PERCEIVED CONTROL**

The final set of hypotheses directly test Karasek's theory of work-family conflict. An extension of his theory would predict that roles with

equal demands will differ in the amount of overload or interference experienced depending on an individual's level of control over the situation. In support of this, Pleck, Staines, and Lang (1980) found that employees who had lower control over the decision to work overtime, the ability to change their work schedule, or the ability to take time off work for personal or family matters were significantly more likely to experience high levels of work-family conflict. The hypotheses are as follows:

- H6: Individuals with low control will experience more role overload than will those with high control.
- H7: Individuals with low control will experience more interference from work to family than will those with high control.
- H8: Individuals with low control will experience more interference from family to work than will those with high control.

## METHOD

### SAMPLE

The data presented in this article come from a Canadian survey on issues related to balancing work and family. The 20,836 respondents to this survey were from two sources: a random sample of all Canadian federal public-sector employees working in the National Capital Region ( $N = 6,287$ ) and a cross section of private-sector employees from large, geographically diverse organizations ( $N = 14,549$ ). The responses came from employees in seven government departments and 37 private-sector organizations. All surveys were distributed through the internal mail system of each organization and were returned to us unopened to protect confidentiality. Across these organizations, we averaged a 56% response rate. The respondents were geographically dispersed, representing individuals living in 408 different Canadian population centers.

Many individual and organizational factors have an impact on work-family conflict. To minimize the influence of nonmeasured confounds and to make the population as homogeneous as possible, the sample was limited to males and females who met the following criteria. They had to have full-time (i.e., greater than 37 hours per week) paid employment outside the home and be parents of children ages 6 through 12 who were living at home 100% of the time. The restriction to children in the age range of 6 through 12 was based on several reasons. First, our sample of single parents with children under 6 years of age was too small for

**TABLE 1**  
**Sample Size**

| <i>Family Type/Control</i> | <i>Male</i> | <i>Female</i> |
|----------------------------|-------------|---------------|
| Married/low control        | 315         | 382           |
| Married/high control       | 508         | 414           |
| Single parent/low control  | 50          | 143           |
| Single parent/high control | 57          | 120           |

statistical analyses. This is due to the fact that single parents with young children are not as likely to be in the workforce as are those with older children. (According to 1993 Statistics Canada data, only 33% of single parents with children under the age of 6 were in the workforce compared to 69% of single parents with children 12 and older.) Second, the age range from 6 to 12 is in itself quite interesting. This is a time period when children are in school but are still highly dependent on their parent(s). Third, by restricting the sample to families with children in this age range, we eliminated confounds associated with comparing families with different-age children. For example, we would not be comparing a family with teenagers to a family with a 7-year-old and a 9-year-old.

These criteria were met by 1,989 respondents. Marital status, gender, and perceived control (described later) were used to subdivide this sample into the eight groupings shown in Table 1.

Table 2 shows the demographic characteristics of the sample. There were some significant differences related to age, the most notable being that men in the sample were slightly older than the women. Number of children was comparable across all groups. Mean age of the children was also similar across the groups with the exception of female single parents in the high-control category. For this group, children were significantly older. Men had significantly higher levels of education and income than did women.

#### THE INSTRUMENT

Data were collected using a 21-page survey instrument that tapped a variety of individual, organizational, and family variables. Most of the items in the questionnaire were collected for other research purposes and are not reported here. Those that are relevant are discussed in the following paragraphs.

TABLE 2  
Sample Demographics

| Family Type/Control        | Age  |     |        |     | Number of Children |     |        |     | Mean Age of Children |     |        |     | Percent With University Education |      |        |     | Percent With Income > \$60,000 |   |        |   |
|----------------------------|------|-----|--------|-----|--------------------|-----|--------|-----|----------------------|-----|--------|-----|-----------------------------------|------|--------|-----|--------------------------------|---|--------|---|
|                            | Male |     | Female |     | Male               |     | Female |     | Male                 |     | Female |     | Male                              |      | Female |     | Male                           |   | Female |   |
|                            | x    | s   | x      | s   | x                  | s   | x      | s   | x                    | s   | x      | s   | x                                 | s    | x      | s   | x                              | s | x      | s |
| Married/low control        | 39.5 | 5.6 | 36.3   | 5.2 | 1.8                | .7  | 1.7    | .7  | 8.1                  | 2.9 | 8.2    | 2.6 | 36.1                              | 13.6 | 24.3   | 3.7 |                                |   |        |   |
| Married/high control       | 39.4 | 5.8 | 36.3   | 5.9 | 1.8                | .7  | 1.7    | .7  | 8.2                  | 2.9 | 7.8    | 3.3 | 31.2                              | 19.3 | 26.0   | 4.9 |                                |   |        |   |
| Single parent/low control  | 38.5 | 6.2 | 35.7   | 4.9 | 1.6                | .8  | 1.7    | 1.1 | 7.7                  | 3.3 | 8.1    | 3.0 | 38.0                              | 11.9 | 18.0   | 2.8 |                                |   |        |   |
| Single parent/high control | 39.4 | 6.2 | 38.7   | 8.8 | 1.8                | 1.6 | 1.6    | .9  | 8.6                  | 2.7 | 6.8    | 4.3 | 36.9                              | 14.3 | 28.6   | 2.5 |                                |   |        |   |



Work-family conflict (role overload, interference from work to family, interference from family to work) was operationalized using the work-family role strain instrument developed by Bohlen and Viveros-Long (1981). This instrument asks respondents to indicate, using a five-point Likert scale, the extent to which they agree or disagree with a number of statements. High scores indicate greater agreement and hence higher role overload and role interference.

Five statements were used to measure role overload: (a) I feel I have more to do than I can comfortably handle, (b) I feel physically drained when I get home from work, (c) I feel emotionally drained when I get home from work, (d) I feel I have to rush to get everything done each day, and (e) I feel I don't have enough time for myself.

Four statements were used to assess the extent to which the respondent perceived that work interfered with family: (a) I wish I had more time to do things for the family, (b) My time off work does not match other family members' schedules well, (c) My job keeps me away from my family too much, and (d) I have a good balance between my job and my family time (reverse coded).

Five statements were used to measure interference from family to work: (a) Family life interferes with work, (b) I worry about whether I should work less and spend more time with my children, (c) I worry about my children when I am working, (d) I am comfortable with the arrangements for my children while I am working (reverse coded), and (e) Making arrangements for my children while I work involves a lot of effort.

To measure perceived control, four statements from Cohen, Kamarck, and Mermelstein's (1983) perceived stress scale were used. Respondents were asked to respond on a scale of 1 (*never*) to 5 (*always*) to the following statements: (a) Felt that you were unable to control important things in your life, (b) Been able to control irritations in your life, (c) Been angered because of things that happened that were outside of your control, and (d) Been able to control the way you spent your time. Although this scale was not designed to measure perceived control, the questions appear to have reasonable face validity.

To dichotomize the control variable, an arithmetic average was taken using the four statements. Individuals with mean scores greater than 3 were deemed to have high control. Those with scores 3 or below were deemed to have low control.

The intercorrelations of variables are shown in Table 3. High correlations were noted among the three dependent variables. There were also high negative correlations between perceived control and the dependent variables—that is, high levels of control were associated with lower levels

**TABLE 3**  
**Intercorrelation of Variables**

| <i>Variable</i> | <i>Gender</i> | <i>Family Type</i> | <i>Control</i> | <i>Overload</i> | <i>Work to Family</i> | <i>Family to Work</i> |
|-----------------|---------------|--------------------|----------------|-----------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|
| Gender          | —             |                    |                |                 |                       |                       |
| Family type     | .11**         | —                  |                |                 |                       |                       |
| Control         | -.09**        | -.04*              | —              |                 |                       |                       |
| Overload        | .24**         | .02                | -.33**         | —               |                       |                       |
| Work to family  | .11**         | .03                | -.28**         | .53**           | —                     |                       |
| Family to work  | .13**         | .03                | -.30**         | .42**           | .54**                 | —                     |

\* $p < .05$ ; \*\* $p < .01$ .

of overload and interference. Reliabilities for the scales were .85 for overload, .67 for work interference with family, .69 for family interference with work, and .61 for perceived control. The reliabilities of the interference scales fell just below Nunnally's (1978) guideline of .7 for exploratory research. The control scale was unacceptable by Nunnally's standards but, given that it was being used as a dichotomous independent variable, it was retained in the analysis.

Time in work and family roles was obtained by asking the respondent, "On your last regular work day, approximately how many hours did you spend in the following activities? (a) working at the office, (b) working at home (job related), (c) in home chores and errands, and (d) in activities with your children." Working at the office and at home were summed to compute hours in work activities. Home chores and errands and activities with children were summed to get a measure of family activities. These data are shown in Table 4.

Women spent significantly less time in work activities and more time in family activities than did men. For total hours in work and family, women spent significantly more hours. There were no significant differences across family type or perceived control in hours spent in work or family activities.

#### DATA ANALYSIS

Data analysis was performed using a MANOVA with three independent variables (gender, family type, perceived control) and three dependent variables (overload, interference from work to family, interference from family to work). All interactions were tested. Following a significant MANOVA, univariate  $F$  tests were conducted using a Bonferroni

TABLE 4  
Hours in Various Activities

| Family Type/Control        | Work Activities |     |        |     | Family Activities |     |        |     | Total Hours in Work and Family |     |        |     |
|----------------------------|-----------------|-----|--------|-----|-------------------|-----|--------|-----|--------------------------------|-----|--------|-----|
|                            | Male            |     | Female |     | Male              |     | Female |     | Male                           |     | Female |     |
|                            | x               | s   | x      | s   | x                 | s   | x      | s   | x                              | s   | x      | s   |
| Married/low control        | 9.0             | 2.0 | 8.4    | 1.7 | 3.4               | 1.7 | 4.5    | 1.8 | 12.3                           | 2.2 | 12.8   | 2.3 |
| Married/high control       | 8.8             | 1.7 | 8.3    | 1.8 | 3.4               | 1.4 | 4.5    | 2.0 | 12.1                           | 1.9 | 12.7   | 2.5 |
| Single parent/low control  | 8.6             | 2.0 | 8.3    | 1.6 | 3.7               | 2.0 | 4.6    | 1.6 | 12.2                           | 2.7 | 12.9   | 2.2 |
| Single parent/high control | 8.7             | 2.2 | 8.4    | 1.3 | 3.5               | 2.0 | 4.4    | 1.8 | 12.0                           | 2.6 | 12.7   | 2.0 |

**TABLE 5**  
**Overload**

| <i>Family Type/Control</i> | <i>Male</i> |     | <i>Female</i> |     |
|----------------------------|-------------|-----|---------------|-----|
|                            | x           | s   | x             | s   |
| Married/low control        | 3.7         | 0.7 | 4.0           | 0.7 |
| Married/high control       | 3.1         | 0.8 | 3.5           | 0.8 |
| Single parent/low control  | 3.6         | 0.9 | 3.9           | 0.8 |
| Single parent/high control | 3.0         | 0.8 | 3.6           | 0.9 |

**TABLE 6**  
**Work Interferes With Family**

| <i>Family/Job Type</i>     | <i>Male</i> |     | <i>Female</i> |     |
|----------------------------|-------------|-----|---------------|-----|
|                            | x           | s   | x             | s   |
| Married/low control        | 3.3         | 0.7 | 3.4           | 0.7 |
| Married/high control       | 2.8         | 0.8 | 3.0           | 0.8 |
| Single parent/low control  | 3.4         | 0.7 | 3.4           | 0.7 |
| Single parent/high control | 2.8         | 0.7 | 3.1           | 0.9 |

adjustment (i.e., we divided the overall alpha of .05 by the number of dependent variables).

## RESULTS

The interaction terms were not significant. The main effects of gender [Hotelling's = .035,  $F(3, 1979) = 22.9$ ,  $p < .001$ ], family type [Hotelling's = .006,  $F(3, 1979) = 4.1$ ,  $p < .01$ ], and perceived control [Hotelling's = .077,  $F(3, 1979) = 50.6$ ,  $p < .001$ ] were significant. The univariate  $F$  test for each hypothesis is discussed in the following paragraphs. Data for role overload can be found in Table 5. Work to family interference data are shown in Table 6, and family to work data are shown in Table 7.

Hypotheses 1 and 3 stated that mothers would experience more overload and interference from family to work than would fathers. Hypothesis 1 was supported. Women had significantly higher levels of overload than did men,  $F(1, 1981) = 66.8$ ,  $p < .001$ . Hypothesis 3 was not supported although the results approached significance ( $p = .053$  exceeded the

**TABLE 7**  
**Family Interferes With Work**

| <i>Family Type/Control</i> | <i>Male</i> |     | <i>Female</i> |     |
|----------------------------|-------------|-----|---------------|-----|
|                            | x           | s   | x             | s   |
| Married/low control        | 3.0         | 0.6 | 3.1           | 0.7 |
| Married/high control       | 2.4         | 0.7 | 2.7           | 0.8 |
| Single parent/low control  | 3.0         | 0.7 | 3.1           | 0.8 |
| Single parent/high control | 2.7         | 0.8 | 2.7           | 0.8 |

critical value of .0167). Hypothesis 2 stated that men would experience more work to family interference than would mothers. Interference from work to family was actually higher for women,  $F(1, 1981) = 7.1, p < .01$ , which is opposite to our hypothesized direction.

Hypotheses 4 and 5 stated that single parents would experience higher levels of overload and interference from family to work than would married parents. Neither of these hypotheses was supported even though the overall MANOVA was significant. For family interference with work (hypothesis 5), single parents had slightly higher levels than did their married counterparts,  $F(1, 1981) = 4.6, p = .033$ , which is slightly above the critical .025 level required by a Bonferroni adjustment.

Hypotheses 6, 7, and 8 stated that individuals with low control would experience more overload, more interference from work to family, and more interference from family to work than would those with high control. All three hypotheses were supported. Those with low control had significantly higher levels of overload [ $F(1, 1981) = 113.0, p < .001$ ], interference from work to family [ $F(1, 1981) = 87.3, p < .001$ ], and interference from family to work [ $F(1, 1981) = 79.4, p < .001$ ].

## DISCUSSION

### THE RATIONAL MODEL

According to the rational model, the more time spent in a role, the more work-family conflict that will be experienced. In this sample, women spent more time in total work and family activities than did men (see Table 4). The fact that they experienced higher levels of overload is thus consistent with the rational model of work-family conflict. Women also

spent more time in family activities and experienced higher levels of family interference with work. Again, this is consistent with the rational model.

Contrary to the rational model, women experienced significantly more interference from work to family than did men despite the fact that they actually spend less time in work activities than do their male counterparts (see Table 4). This inconsistency with the rational model has two potential explanations. First, it may be that the perception of interference from work to family is a function of sociocultural expectations (see Galinsky et al., 1991; Hochschild, 1989; Schwartz, 1992). Sociocultural expectations theory suggests that role expectations will affect men's and women's perceptions of work-family conflict differently (Gutek et al., 1991). It predicts that hours spent working in the opposite sex's domain ought to have a greater psychological impact on a person's perceptions of work-family conflict than should hours spent in his or her own domain (Gutek et al., 1991). Thus women should report higher levels of interference from work to family than should men (Gutek et al., 1991). Second, the gender difference in interference from work to family may also be partially due to the fact that women are more likely than men to assume responsibility for home chores and child care functions that occur at the beginning or end of the work day. The execution of these family obligations is, by virtue of work and family schedules, more likely to come in conflict with work demands and hence increase the perception of interference from work to family. It should be recognized, however, that the division of child care and home chores is ultimately a function of sociocultural expectations.

The relationship among family type, role overload, and interference from family to work was unexpected. Examination of the time data indicate that single parents spent the same amount of time in total and family activities as did their married counterparts. This result was unexpected; previous literature indicates that role demands are greater in single-parent households because one person must perform most of the family tasks that are performed by two partners in a dual-income family (Lee, 1983; Voydanoff, 1987). In terms of our underlying theory, the rational model is supported. Because single parents did not spend more time in work and family roles, they would not be expected to have higher levels of overload or interference.

#### **KARASEK'S JOB STRAIN MODEL**

The highly significant results obtained for perceived control is supportive of using Karasek's job strain model to predict work-family conflict.

Individuals with low control had significantly higher levels of overload, interference from work to family, and interference from family to work than did those with high control. This occurred despite the fact that both groups of individuals spent similar amounts of time in work and family activities.

These results indicate that the rational model, by itself, does not fully explain what is happening. Given equal time in work and family activities, the rational model would posit equal levels of overload and interference. This did not occur, indicating that perceptions of control are important. Fortunately, it is in situations in which there are equal demands that Karasek's model is applicable (i.e., the prediction is for jobs with similar demands or expectations). In these cases, Karasek's model predicts that individuals with higher control will experience less work-family conflict. This was observed in our sample.

## LIMITATIONS

This research has several limitations. First, our measure of perceived control was not taken from a validated instrument. We extracted four questions that appeared to measure control from Cohen, Kamarck and Mermelstein's (1983) perceived stress scale. Future research should measure control over the work domain and control over the family domain. A second limitation is the relatively low Cronbach alphas for the two interference measures. Future research needs to use more reliable scales such as the ones recently developed by Gutek and her associates (1991). A third limitation of the research is the relatively small number of male single parents.

## CONCLUSIONS

The results from this research support Karasek's job strain model but do not support the rational model. When demands are greater (i.e., work or family), individuals should, according to the rational model, experience higher levels of overload and interference. The fact that women had higher levels of interference from work to family than did men despite women's spending less time in work activities contradicts the rational model. In all cases, however, those with low control experienced higher levels of overload and interference.

It appears that one way to address the problem would be to change the way we organize and structure work to make it easier for both men and

women to combine work and family roles. Individuals need more flexibility and control over when and where they work. Organizations that provide support for their employees (i.e., flextime, part-time employment, family-leave days, job sharing) might ultimately benefit their human resources component by having a workforce free of excessive levels of overload and interference. This is important because overload and interference have been associated with various negative consequences including increased health risks; decreased productivity; increased tardiness, absenteeism, and turnover; and poor morale (Greenhaus & Beutell, 1985; Kelly & Voydanoff, 1985; Pleck, 1985; Pleck, Staines, & Lang, 1980; Portner, 1983; Voydanoff, 1987).

A second, and not unexpected, finding from this study is the vulnerability of women to work-family conflict. The data show quite clearly that mothers experience more role overload, interference from work to family, and interference from family to work than do men. This suggests that combining paid employment with responsibilities at home is more problematic for women than it is for men. Women experience more problems because their family and combined work and family demands are higher. However, the question remains, Why do women spend more time in, and assume greater responsibility for, home chores and child care? Women have now been actively involved in the paid workforce for several decades. They are actively contributing to the financial support of their families. It appears, however, that the traditional division of family chores by gender and the expectations that women place on themselves and their family have changed little over the years. In other words, the sociocultural expectation that women will retain primary responsibility for the home, regardless of their employment status, makes women more susceptible to work/family conflict.

Finally, the surprising finding that single mothers and fathers report no more overload and interference from family to work than do their married counterparts suggests that the actual work and family situation is not more trying for them despite the fact that they have only one parent at home. As one mother noted, "Half my problems walked out the door when he left."

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